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Borghesia Mafiosa: Organized Crime, Media Branding, and Neoliberal Upper-Class Politics in Italy

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ABSTRACT
Within neoliberal governance contexts, such as those shaping contemporary Italy, brands serves as powerful socio-cultural interfaces, extracting social and symbolic capital from the relational labour embedded in their media circulation and consumption. Socio-legally diverse members of the current Italian upper classes (including leaders of criminal organizations, members of the so-called 'mafia bourgeoisie,' enterpreneurs, professional politicians, and cadres of state-regulated civic institutions) increasingly rely on media self-branding, often involving the circulation of their public images, to establish forms of connective leadership over their audiences. As such, they engender dynamics of class privilege reproduction that diverge from the bureaucratised processes of power management historically involving the capitalist bourgeoisie. This paper ethnographically compares how licit and illicit Italian upper classes engage with media self-branding, examining their complementary roles in shaping neoliberal modalities of governmentality that, transcending any discursive dichotomy between formal and informal, influence the inner workings of the current Italian public sphere.

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KEYWORDS Bourgeoisie; organised crime; branding; digital media; class; neoliberalism; Italy

Introduction

On the 16th of January 2023, the Italian Carabinieri arrested former *capo dei capi* of the Sicilian Mafia Matteo Messina Denaro at a clinic in Palermo, Sicily, where he was temporarily hospitalised (Picarella and Sciarrone 2023). This capture significantly affected Italian politics, economy, and public security. The boss was indeed not only involved in some of the most violent crime massacres plaguing the country since the 1990s (Picarella and Sciarrone 2023: 3). As the top manager of a major criminal organisation, he wielded influence over Italian politics and economics through extensive patronage networks involving key figures in public and private institutions, overseeing an illegal financial empire valued at approximately 4 billion euros (Amadore 2023: 4). Due to the ample coverage that Italian media gave to the capture of such a powerful mobster, this arrest has also opened a window on various aspects of a Mafia boss' life. For example, it provided insights into how criminal leaders manage their public images and those of their organisations, effectively turning them into iconic brands, to legitimize extra-legal power management in neoliberal democracies like the Italian Republic.

In this sense, two seemingly contradictory aspects of Messina Denaro's habits are particularly significant. The first is the condition of relative 'invisibility' from public security authorities that

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characterised the Mafia boss' daily interactions with the others before his arrest. While being wanted by the police forces of the entire planet, Messina Denaro managed to safely engage with the inhabitants (and even the public offices) of Campobello di Mazara, the Sicilian town where he used to hide from law enforcement, for about 30 years (Tondo 2023).

According to Maurizio De Lucia, the Chief Prosecutor of the Court of Palermo, the boss' seemingly ghost-like ability to interact with the public sphere for such a long time without leaving any concrete evidence of his presence in town—and thereby justifying a complex and resource-intensive operation like his arrest—was not solely due to the extra-legal territorial control that his organisation maintained over Campobello di Mazara through intimidation and bribery (Giornale di Sicilia 2023). This outstanding ability to avoid the public authorities' gaze was instead to be largely attributed to the tacit legitimisation Messina Denaro received from local and national members of the so-called *borghesia mafiosa*—the 'mafia bourgeoisie'—, who contributed to 'normalizing' his longstanding presence in the Sicilian village (as well as his social role as a Mafia leader) within the local cultural imaginary (Giornale di Sicilia 2023).

Originally developed by Mineo (1995), the term *borghesia mafiosa* defines a social formation composed of upper-class individuals with no criminal records nor formal ties to organised crime, who operate within the ranks of state-regulated civil society while benefitting from personal connections, clientelistic relationships, and informal exchanges of favours they entertain with the affiliated members of criminal organisations (128). According to Santino (2023), illicit syndicates such as the Sicilian Mafia could not exercise their power without these upper-class sectors of society. The interpersonal connections between professional criminals and mafia bourgeoisie members indeed create strong socio-cultural bridges between criminal authorties and state-regulated politico-economic agencies. These relationships effectively legitimize organised crime's actions and bolster its political and economic influence on significant portions of society (including non-criminal lower-class and middle-class subjects entertaining subaltern power relationships with mafia bourgeoisie members such as their employees, voters, etc.), further legitimising and overall increasing the extra-legal forms of territorial control it exercises in discoursive terms (Santino 2023: 23).

In short, the clientelist networks interconnecting the social lives and private interests of organised crime affiliates and members of the mafia bourgeoisie enable criminal organisations like the Sicilian Mafia to productively intersect the public spheres of capitalist democracies as eminently inter-classist socio-cultural agencies (Santino 2023: 64). From a political standpoint, this allows criminal cartels to intermediate potential class struggles by coagulating self-legitimating 'historic blocs'—a term employed by Gramsci (1975 [1929–1935]]) to address the contextual relationship between the economic practices, social hierarchies, and cultural values of a given society (465)—around their financial activities, thus exercising forms of hegemony over extended portions of the social spaces they inhabit. From an organisational point of view, moreover, systemic collusions between professional criminals and the mafia bourgeoisie allow criminal organisations to continuously adapt their operations' range, scope, and methods, integrating emerging politico-economic practices within their previous *modus operandi* depending on the diverse dynamics of power management in which their upper-class counterparts are engaged (Santino 2023: 36).

This latest manifestation of the mafia bourgeoisie's influence in contemporary Italy, combined with the specific modalities of class privilege reproduction exercised by the current Italian upper classes, is vividly exemplified by the second notable feature of Messina Denaro's habits: the conditions of hyper-visibility surrounding his private sphere, particularly in his role as Mafia leader. As emerged after the boss' arrest, Messina Denaro asserted his Mafia rank via repeated symbolic appropriations of mainstream media aesthetics. The boss, for example, used to display a full collection of gadgets and paintings inspired by popular Hollywood gangster movies like 'The Godfather' saga and 'Joker' inside the apartment where he lived, met his clients, and led his cartel (Sirignano 2023). Furthermore, he also used to share selfies with circles of 'fans', including one of the doctors working at the clinic where he was arrested, for them to be reposted online and turn 'viral' among

social media users (Spica 2023). In this sense, the boss strategically circulated both his factual image (e.g.: his selfies) and symbolic representations of it (e.g.: popular depictions of cinematic icons) through practices of media self-branding aiming to elicit political capital out of selected audiences and legitimating his status and agency among extended networks.

The term 'brand' defines a semiotic device engendering a symbolic relationship between the aesthetic elements that identify a set of products, services, or public personas and some predefined cultural characteristics promoted by those endorsing the brand itself and its circulation (Arvidsson 2006; Lury 2004). These characteristics, which constitute the brand's 'personality', can be further legitimised by brand audiences through media consumption practices that might, at least in theory, enhance their social conditions by fostering trans-class processes of interpersonal relationality with the brand owners (Nakassis 2013: 116). Due to these features, the concept of branding, originally coined as a technical term to describe marketing strategies leading to strictly financial outcomes, has increasingly transcended its economistic origins. Having been better redefined as a semiotic tool of cultural production (Manning 2010), branding has evolved into one of the primary techniques of power management that shape the political lives of current neoliberal democracies (Nakassis 2013).

In these contexts, as Arvidsson (2006) and Poell *et al.* (2016) explain, various prominent social actors—electoral candidates, civil society operators, media celebrities, online social media influencers, and even Mafia bosses—engage in personalistic processes of self-branding involving the commodification and strategic circulation of their public personas as a political strategy improving their agency over selected pools of media consumers. Their goal is to establish and discoursively 'naturalize' indirect, as well as largely unregulated, conditions of leadership on such audiences by influencing their media consumption habits (and the social imaginary associated with them), transcending any political message tied to the commodity-images in question in a populistic fashion[1] (Poell *et al.* 2016: 1001). Rather than financial dynamics of capital accumulation, therefore, these processes of self-branding emphasise relational influence, symbolic capital, and the affective outcomes implicit in any act of media consumption (Mazzarella 2020), which are instrumental in shaping political perceptions and building authority within their respective areas of interest (Arvidsson 2006: 88).

What is the political role played by organised crime processes of self-branding in contemporary Italy? How do they socio-culturally intersect the parallel activities of self-branding exercised by non-criminal upper-class Italian subjects such as the leaders of political parties and state-regulated civic organisations? How does the interplay between licit and illicit processes of self-branding, in tandem with the dynamics of relationality it entails, contribute to the increasing entrenchment of the *borghesia mafiosa*? What can it reveal about the forms of power management shaping the public sphere of contemporary neoliberal Italy, together with its upper-class politics and the dynamics of social privilege reproduction they engender? I will answer these questions by comparing the political processes of media self-branding in which current Italian upper-class subjects operating either within organised crime or state-regulated organisations respectively partake.

As hinted before, the notion of 'brand' has been recently explored by a growing multidisciplinary literature, which addressed its capacity to serve as the main interface of contemporary capitalist processes of financial accumulation (Lury 2004), its ability to performatively adapt to shifting political frameworks even beyond its financial features (Nakassis 2013), and its potentiality to trigger grassroots change (Poell *et al.* 2016). Brands are indeed powerful interfaces between their promoters and their publics (Lury 2004: 6), generating political, social, and economic capital through the forms of immaterial labour embedded in the clientelistic sociability they elicit among media consumers (Lury 2004: 11; Lazzarato 1997). In fact, the value of a brand derives from the degree of social engagement it stimulates among its consumers, which in turn defines its capacity to influence their commercial habits, personal identities, and interactions with the public sphere (Arvidsson 2006: 13–14).

As I anticipated earlier, the mechanisms of interpersonal relationality inherent to branding have become central to the processes of power management that, starting in the 1990s, have increasingly

characterised civic participation in neoliberal democracies, including Italy (Arvidsson 2006: 90; Lury 2004: 23). As shown by Poell *et al.* (2016), for example, digital activities of brand consumption and re-circulation by social media users (including change-seeking activists but also, I argue, those re-posting Messina Denaro's selfies on their social media accounts) allow branders to partake in connective types of leadership aiming at indirectly disciplining social relationships around the consumption of specific commodity-images (1004). In this sense, the dynamics of connective leadership elicited by neoliberal processes of political self-branding seem central to the growing entrenchment of the *borghesia mafiosa* recently assessed by Chief Prosecutor De Lucia, as well as the increasing legitimisation of this social formation in contemporary neoliberal Italy.

Reflecting on systemic forms of collusion between non-criminal upper-class subjects (public and corporate cadres, NGO operators and managers; professional politicians, etc.) and organised crime, a rich criminological literature illustrates them as intrinsically subversive to actual systems of governance since they are regulated by interpersonal relationships rather than public bureaucracies (Catino 2019; Sciarrone 2010; Ruggiero 1993). Some scholars interpret such collusions as symptomatic of the fact that their protagonists partake in cultural conditions of 'pre-modernity' and 'amoral familism' (Catino 2019; Banfield 1967 [1958]). Others instead describe them as the product of quite 'modern' forms of capitalist subjectivity (Gambetta 2009; Pardo 1996; Ruggiero 1993). Despite such divergences, this literature consistently describes the *borghesia mafiosa* participating in these collusive processes as the inhabitants of 'grey zones' between the legal and the illegal, which they co-instantiate with organised criminals via informal practices of trust-building (Gambetta 2009) and affective commonalities they share in context (Pine 2012).

By describing the mafia bourgeoisie through its defiance of state power and reliance on subversive processes of informal relationality, however, this scholarship might risk advancing misleading representations of the processes of sociability from which current instantiations of this social formation emerge. According to further literature in political anthropology and critical social theory, in fact, organised crime and public institutions partake in complementary dynamics of capitalist governmentality, rather than Manichean distinctions between the legal and illegal, under neoliberal conditions of governance (Rakopoulos 2017; Nordstrom 2007; Rodgers 2006; Chatterjee 2004). This stems from the neoliberal public sphere's reliance on consumer-driven approaches to civic participation (Harvey 2005) and immaterial forms of relational labour (Baym 2015; Elyachar 2010). As reminded by Hardt and Negri (2004), these features lead neoliberal societies to be disciplined by the individualistic efforts of an atomised 'multitude' of entrepreneurial citizens who, from diverse social positions, engage in market-driven forms of political agency—including those shaped by media self-branding. Such forms of agency encompass the normative discourses that have historically influenced both the management of organised crime violence (286) and state-regulated bureaucracies (206). Accordingly, the fields or relationality engendered by self-branding activities do not just concern contextual alliances between professional mobsters, unscrupulous upper-class people, and their respective audiences. They are also central to political dynamics of value creation (Lury 2004), cultural production (Giusto 2019), and social representation (Gupta 1995) shaping the neoliberal public sphere itself and the forms of inequality permeating it on a global scale.

In essence, the socio-political interactions elicited by personalistic forms of media branding possess an inherent ability to bypass state bureaucracy while significantly influencing the internal dynamics of the neoliberal public sphere. As such, the manifestations of *borghesia mafiosa* arising from these branded interactions do not appear to be shaped, as Pine (2012) and Gambetta (2009) suggest, by the presence of intermixed 'grey zone' blurring the boundaries between formal and informal power management. Much like the practices of favour exchange and politico-economic relationality examined by Rakopoulos (2020) in his recent ethnography of the symbolic conflict between the Mafia and anti-Mafia civil society in rural Sicily, these phenomena seem to stem from patterns of political action transcending any conceptual distinctions, or even 'grey' intermingling, between formal and informal realms.

Building on these considerations, this paper will assess the role of media self-branding dynamics within organised crime and state-regulated processes of upper-class privilege reproduction that, going beyond any rigid dichotomy between the legal and the extra-legal, ultimately contribute to the deepening entrenchment of the *borghesia mafiosa* in contemporary neoliberal Italy. As such, my work will examine the forms of relational labour prompted by Italian organised crime and state-regulated processes of brand circulation, as well as the dynamics of connective leadership through which the media consumption of brands reinforces manifestations of the so-called mafia bourgeoisie within the national public sphere.

To accomplish this goal, I will analyze and compare selected case studies concerning the activities of media self-branding enacted by two socio-legally diverse types of current Italian subjects of upper-class background. In the next section, I will illustrate the self-branding activities exercised by affiliated members of criminal organisations and integral components of the *borghesia mafiosa*, such as the managers and operators of the media outlets that, as I will show, have been implemented and sponsored by the Sicilian Mafia, the Neapolitan Camorra, and the Calabrese 'Ndrangheta. In the following section, I will instead describe the self-branding activities exercised by the upper-class leaders and coordinators of current Italian state-regulated civic organisations such as political parties and NGOs.

These two sets of case studies and their subsequent comparative analysis will rely on data I gathered via archival research of recent Italian journalistic sources and public records concerning the activities of self-branding in question and their outcomes. I will complement these data with ethnographic insights I have collected in Naples and Palermo—two cities long shaped by the persistent presence of organised crime since the nineteenth century[2]– from May to October 2023, when I conducted fieldwork research on the phenomena at stake in this paper.

I initially contacted my research participants via online social media to observe and participate in the branding dynamics in which they engaged through such platforms, the interpersonal relationships that these processes elicited in context, and their discursive outcomes. Subsequently, I scheduled in-person meetings with them to collect their consent to participate in my research, observe and participate in the practices of media branding in which they were involved, and conduct semi-structured interviews with them. None of my research participants has ever been convicted or sentenced for organised-crime-related felonies. Nevertheless, I will conceal their real names and identities for privacy and security reasons.

In the closing section of the paper, I will finally answer the driving question inspiring my research. At the same time, I will advocate for a broader interdisciplinary debate on the role played by licit and illicit instantiations of media self-branding, in tandem with their potential capacity to trigger social change, within the processes of class privilege reproduction characterising contemporary global contexts of neoliberal governance.

Cosa Vostra: Media Branding and Organized Crime Politics

Messina Denaro was not the only Italian crime boss relying on self-branding to elicit socio-political advantages. Several contemporary and affiliates of the Sicilian Mafia, Neapolitan Camorra, and Calabrese 'Ndrangheta engage in similar practices via their instrumental management of analog and digital media outlets. These three organisations constitute the most financially relevant and politically influential cartels aminating the current Italian underworld (DIA 2022: 18–19). While outlining their specific peculiarities goes beyond the scope of this paper, highlighting some of their shared characteristics could be valuable in illustrating their historical socio-political role in Italy and the motivations behind their engagement in media branding.

Current scholarship seems divided in assessing the three organisations' historical origins. Pinpointing similarities between the initiation rituals and codes of conduct that they respectively promoted during the last two centuries, for example, Dickie (2014) argues that the three organised crime agencies shared common roots, constituting different faces of the same 'criminal ecosystem'

since their early formations. Other scholars claimed that they emerged from diverse historical contingencies (including their contextual relationships with various forms of state power and, since the end of IIWW, also with extra-Italian criminal organisations such as Italian-American *Cosa Nostra*), which shaped them into radically different (as well as constantly changing) instantiations of organised crime (Lupo 2011; Allum 2006). Nevertheless, these diverse on the history of Italian mobsters agree on the fact that Mafia, Camorra, and 'Ndrangheta share at least a few common historical features, having been similarly constituted immediately after the political unification of the Italian peninsula in the mid-nineteenth-century.

Since then, their enduring ability to intersect the public sphere appears to be equally rooted in the unequal forms of public intervention through which the Italian central state has continuously fostered conditions of privilege in the industrialised Northern regions of the country versus the South (Gramsci 2006 [1926]; Dickie 2014; Lupo 2011). Taking advantage of this ongoing 'Southern Question' (Gramsci 2006 [1926]), the nineteenth-century gangs[3] that subsequently developed into the criminal organisations in question increasingly specialised in extra-legal social protection activities, which they offered (and quite often violently enforced) to local lower-class and middle-class subjects in exchange for bribes and racket fees (Sciarrone 2010; Allum 2006; Gambetta 1996). Therefore, the three organisations' capacity to accumulate economic capital and socio-political credibility amid local and national social spaces hinges on their historical propensity toward interpersonal rings of service provision co-involving multiple classes of subjects vis-à-vis highly bureaucratised and scarcely accessible public institutions.

This contentious legacy persists today in the social peripheries of major Southern Italian cities like Naples and Palermo. Havin conducted fieldwork research in the working-class neighbourhoods of these cities in a post-COVID context, several residents described how local mobsters regularly delivered groceries to the elderly throughout the pandemic, shielding them from exposure to the virus in exchange for a modest weekly fee. Interestingly, local residents could request this 'illicit' service by directly contacting organised crime affiliates (or their intermediaries) via their social media accounts. These accounts served as platforms for such affiliates to assert their controversial authority through self-branding strategies similar to those previously noted in the case of Messina Denaro, including the regular posting of selfies and memes that symbolically linked their public personas to popular cinematic villains.

Secondly, the three organisations underwent comparable dynamics of capitalist hyper-financialization since the 1950s, being similarly inspired by commercial partnerships with further cartels operating transnationally, including Italian-American *Cosa Nostra* and, more recently, Latin-American *Narcos* and Chinese Triads (Sergi and Lavorgna 2016; Allum 2016; 2006; Gambetta 1996). This allowed them to expand exponentially their fields of operation, and the transclass forms of social networking on which they have historically relied, to new geopolitical areas such as Northern Italy, Spain, and Northern Europe (Allum 2016). As such, the three organisations got similarly reformed into increasingly exploitative agencies supervising the transnational traffic of drugs, unregistered labour force, food, real estate, waste disposals, and, more recently, even cryptocurrencies (Sergi and Lavorgna 2016). Due to the capital and labour force they ultimately managed through their involvement in global markets, they became structural components of the Italian political economy, rather than subversive alternatives to its state-regulated forms.

Thirdly, Mafia, 'Ndrangheta, and Camorra similarly tend to express authoritative forms of political and economic agency simultaneously on the most local of grounds—e.g.: among lower-class clients, but also upper-class subjects such as the *borghesia mafiosa* hiding the presence of Messina Denaro in Campobello di Mazara—and transnationally—e.g.: among global market operators—(Sciarrone 2010; Allum 2006). They do so by sponsoring, or violently enforcing, conditions of collusion between the diversely empowered subjects and institutions with whom they enter in touch. As argued by Sciascia (2013 [1972]), thus, the historical success of the three organisations does not rely on their indiscriminate use of violence but on the clientelist activities of political 'intermediation between property and labour, production and consumption, state and citizens' they exercise (12).

As relational labour played such a central role in the historical rise and development of these three criminal organisations, it is hardly surprising that their affiliates have invested conspicuous capital and energies in mechanisms of media self-branding aimed at indirectly disciplining the social lives of their clients. Of course, I am not claiming that organised crime processes of self-branding constitute the only source of relational labour on which Italian cartels rely to consolidate their political agency. Nevertheless, increasing investments in the analog and digital Italian media by prominent figures operating within these organisations allowed them to instantiate self-legitimating processes of branded engagement with multiple classes of media consumers from at least the 1990s.

Since that decade, for example, prominent leaders of the Neapolitan Camorra such as Luigi Giuliano and Vincenzo Oliviero invested significant resources in the production, circulation, and marketing of media productions belonging to the so-called Neomelodica genre (Ghiglione 2022; Giusto 2019; Pine 2012). These popular Camorra-sponsored pop-folk songs, local TV shows, and featured movies intermix traditional Neapolitan aesthetics with those illustrating transnational mainstream media productions (Pine 2012). In so doing, they depict the daily lives of the Neapolitan popular classes in light of their (rather postulated) intimate belonging to the cultural landscape of the Camorra, commonly featuring the heartfelt personal relationships they entertain with drug dealers, hitmen, *latitanti* (runaways from state justice), and prison mates (Giusto 2019; Pine 2012; Ravveduto 2007). Perhaps more importantly, Neomelodica represents Camorra affiliates via stereotypical graphic features that are indeed uncommon among real-life mobsters, such as heavily tanned skins, extensive body tattoos, over-the-top jewelry, and brush-cut hairstyles (Giusto 2019).

As emerged during the ethnography I conducted in Naples, the media circulation of these aesthetic tropes within the local mediascape provides the organised crime producers of Neomelodica with an original and easily recognisable brand. Although only a small number of popular Neomelodica performers have been confirmed as Camorra affiliates (Perna 2013), the genre's aesthetics—along with its effectiveness as a brand promoting Camorra-friendly cultural values—are rooted in specific financial and historical factors. From a financial perspective, the vast majority of Neomelodica media productions are sponsored, produced, and marketed by Camorra clans[4] (Ravveduto 2007). These clans employ a dense network of small media companies to produce Neomelodica, simultaneously using these corporations as channels to launder illicit funds (Giusto 2019; Pine 2012).

Neomelodica has been identified as an original form of cultural production by key members of the Camorra. Since its emergence in the 1990s, many of the genre's most notable works have been authored by influential Camorra bosses as aesthetic manifestos to their clans to be subsequently proposed to local performers, a pattern of media production persisting until the mid-2000s (Ravveduto 2007). As such, the aesthetics of Neomelodica are not shaped into a Camorra brand via cultural appropriation dynamics; rather, they have been historically crafted by upper-class organised crime affiliates as commodity-images originally designed to increase their political and cultural agency as a self-legitimating brand.

The ongoing reiteration of the aesthetics featuring Neomelodica and their symbolic association with organised crime values indeed allows the Camorra to strategically inspire the commercial habits of local media consumers in self-legitimising terms. As such, it also allows this criminal organisation to express political agency in determining the social position of those involved in the making and broadcasting of Neomelodica. Through Camorra-sponsored local television and radio channels, as well as specialised websites and social media profiles, Neapolitan organised crime media producers supervise the circulation of the aesthetic tropes denoting Neomelodica in quasi-monopolistic terms (Giusto 2019). By expressing control over the media circulation of Neomelodica, they implicitly determine who among local performers of popular class backgrounds, and under what conditions of interpersonal proximity with the cartel, can safely appropriate Neomelodica as a brand to achieve local media celebrity, thus improving their

socioeconomic status (Giusto 2019). As explained by a Neapolitan producer of Neomelodica, who also worked as the manager of a Camorra-sponsored local TV network, during an interview I conducted with him:

> The success of Neomelodica does not depend on the talent of its performers only, but on the roguish brand (*il brand un po' mariuolo*) that people like me attach to the artistic skills of such performers. I do that through two main promotional activities. The first concerns the aesthetics we demand the performers of Neomelodica to embody when they are on TV. These aesthetics must represent the personalities of the producers and the local audiences as if they were the same types of people. The second is the door-to-door advertisement (*pubblicità porta a porta*) we conduct via word of mouth or online social media among our contacts and clients. Friendly relations and personal proximity between the producers of Neomelodica, the Camorra clans sponsoring them, and the local performers are always interpreted as a sign of artistic authenticity by the audience, allowing the performers to become famous and improve their living standards.

According to the TV manager, the success of Camorra-sponsored media productions hinges on three factors: (1) their ability to function as impactful brands, symbolically connecting the social identities of their producers, performers, and consumers through shared aesthetics; (2) their marketers' skill in fostering social engagement between their producers and local audiences; and (3) their role in enabling lower-class performers to achieve social mobility by embracing their aesthetics and the Camorra-aligned values they brand. Based on these three factors, the commodification and circulation of the aesthetics illustrating Neomelodica as a brand contribute to engendering original forms of the *borghesia mafiosa* (e.g.: Camorra-sponsored local media operators and media celebrities), who in turn further contribute to 'naturalize' the cumbersome political presence of organised crime within the Neapolitan social peripheries.

Since the mid-2000s, the Sicilian Mafia has also adopted similar strategies of media branding, appropriating reference aesthetics and modalities of media management originally introduced by the Camorra, up to becoming the leading producer of Neomelodica during the following two decades (Ferrara and Petruzzella 2021). They could do so due to one of the main technical features characterising brands as semiotic devices: their capacity to convey multiple layers of meaning at once (thus furthering different modalities of sociability among their consumers) depending on the context in which they are deployed and the social positionality of the subjects circulating them. As Nakassis (2013) suggests, this characteristic enables brands to be appropriated, partially counterfeited, and ultimately re-signified by various (and sometimes competing) actors for their own political and/or economic objectives. Crucially, this occurs without brands entirely losing their original meaning or their ability to generate political, economic, or symbolic capital through media circulation.

As revealed by Lorenza, an online social media manager working for a Mafia-sponsored house of music production based in Palermo, Sicily, during an interview I conducted with her, the most famous Neomelodica artists are currently Sicilian, rather than Neapolitan, as the Mafia manages more resources and know-how to be invested in activities of media branding compared to its Neapolitan competitor. While the aesthetics promoted by the Sicilian Mafia through its approach to Neomelodica contribute to legitimising the Sicilian cartel via brand management practices, they also evoke a wide range of shared cultural values and relational practices that the Mafia share with the Camorra, including their common capacity to potentially fostering social mobility among the media performers they sponsor.

Interestingly, Lorenza also revealed that Mafia-funded media branding activities involving the circulation of Neomelodica aesthetics tend to rely more on digital marketing than those sponsored by the Camorra. This is because most online social media platforms allow users to invest money to boost the algorithmic reach of selected content, enhancing the social diffusion of the branded imagery they feature. In Lorenza's words, this allowed the Mafia to expand the outreach of its communication strategies through new branded processes of interpersonal sociability involving online social media 'influencers' and their 'followers':

> Thanks to online social media, we can easily promote our music, together with the neomelodic style it conveys, outside of Southern Italy. Many national media outlets still refuse to broadcast the music videos we produce due to hypocritical issues of political correctness. Today, we resolve this problem by broadcasting neomelodic content via the profiles of the social media influencers we sponsor. We employ them as brand ambassadors ('*ambasciatori del nostro brand*'). They post our music videos on their social media profiles and use our latest songs as background themes for their most popular videos. All in all, these deals are similar to those the same influencers use to make with any other type of corporation.

Given that, Neomelodica is not the only arena where Italian organised crime cultivates forms of connective leadership via media brand management. Through the appropriation of imaginaries originally introduced by mainstream media, such as those typical of Hollywood gangster movies or those characterising the aesthetic landscape of digital memes and emojis, for example, Italian organised crime affiliates mobilise further acts of branding inside and outside their direct areas of influence. As such, they exploit these media aesthetics' citational features, 'weav[ving] together the multiple 'voices' and identities that inhere' their previous circulation into new forms of clientelist networking involving larger and more cosmopolitan audiences than those usually targeted by Neomelodica (Nakassis 2012: 626).

These further dynamics of organised crime media branding might be exemplified by the digital activities of 'Ndrangheta boss Vincenzo Torcasio (Johnson 2021). Having been condemned to 30 years of reclusion in 2017 for his activities of extortion and murdering, the Calabrese boss spent the previous five years cultivating the engagement rates of *Onore e Dignità* (Honor and Dignity), a Facebook group counting on about 20,000 followers (Cavalli 2017). Torcasio worked as a professional social media influencer, creating and posting hundreds of memes that linked the branded image of Hollywood villains (once again, the Joker and Coppola's Godfather, but also iconic characters such as Al Pacino's Serpico and Scarface) with aphorisms glorifying the supposed cultural values of his organisation (Johnson 2021). These values (precisely 'honour and dignity') constituted the 'personality' of Torcasio's brand. As such, they could be symbolically appropriated by his online followers via media consumption acts like 'liking' and commenting on his posts or reposting them on their social media accounts.

Luisa, a middle-class bank employee from Palermo in her mid-50s and long-time member of the 'Onore e Dignità' Facebook group, commented on how these digital actions by Torcasio's followers fostered broader networks of relationality, interconnecting them to each other, during an interview I conducted with her. In Luisa's opinion, these networks were primarily due to the interactive features of the social media platform through which Torcasio managed his online activities. Luisa and the other Facebook group members received daily updates on Torcasio's new posts, which they regularly 'liked' and commented on in real-time, increasing their outreach.

Moreover, they actively engaged with the Facebook group by sharing original posts on its wall, which were most often inspired by the boss' digital content. These grassroots contributions, in turn, could be further 'liked' and commented on by other members (including Torcasio), fostering a dynamic cycle of interactions. Torcasio's posts often included quotes on how 'men of honour' like himself should confront life's challenges with unwavering determination. Inspired by this theme, many followers, including Luisa, responded to them by sharing their life struggles with similar bravado. This led to private chat conversations between followers facing comparable adversities.

Luisa attributed the relational value of Torcasio's digital posts also to their aesthetic qualities. Detached from their original American cultural meanings, for instance, the Hollywood villains that Torcasio linked to his 'words of wisdom' were never portrayed by their movies of origin as bloodthirsty killers but as multifaceted individuals—often misunderstood underdogs who turned to crime out of necessity or in response to marginalising societal pressures. Due to these characteristics, these anti-heroes (and the boss branding his public persona via them) elicited sympathy and self-identification among Luisa and other followers, especially due to their incapacity to challenge their problems through similar acts of rebellion. In Luisa's words:

> I never met Torcasio in person, but I have followed his Facebook activities since the beginning. Back then, I was attracted by his wisdom and the fierce attitude of his memes. They kept me company in difficult times. Torcasio might be a criminal, but he dared to say openly what many are not brave enough to say. When the rent is too high or we worry because our children can not find a stable job…when we fall sick and must wait forever to get a spot in a public hospital…when we get betrayed by friends or cheated by partners…then we all might want to be like the Joker and, at least metaphorically, laugh hard and shot them all in the face. I don't know anything about organized crime, but 'Onore e Dignità' was a free space to share these feelings and be understood. I cannot say if Torcasio is a bad person. But if he did anything wrong, he might have had some good reasons for doing what he did.

Building on the popularity of his posts and memes, which even featured the logo of Torcasio's Facebook group as a sort of warrant of authenticity, the boss also involved his digital followers in 'Ndrangheta-friendly political campaigns, exercising connective leadership via his social media profiles (Poell *et al.* 2016). Torcasio, for example, associated his memes with Facebook posts mobilising his followers against the involvement of *pentiti* (former organised crime affiliates serving as state justice informants) in Italian courts, as well as calling for reforms of the prison terms concerning organised-crime-related felonies (Cavalli 2017). In so doing, the boss achieved forms of connective agency extending beyond any traditional logic of criminal affiliation, involving multiple classes of Internet users who engaged with his brand via media consumption and overall constituted innovative instantiations of *borghesia mafiosa*.

Made in Italy: Media Branding as a Tool of State-regulated Power Management

The previous examples of how Italian criminal organisations get cultural legitimisation and political agency through their engagement with processes of media self-branding should not be misleading. Such processes, and their outcomes in terms of connective leadership, are not unique to organised crime in contemporary Italy. There, campaigns of media branding sponsored by private corporations and state-regulated civic institutions often intertwine with those conducted by criminal organisations, as they both target similar audiences through common media platforms. Since these platforms are in turn managed by further state-regulated corporations capitalising on their users' engagement with brands, any clear-cut distinction between licit and illicit political activity of media branding tends to be blurred within the neoliberal Italian public sphere. During an interview I conducted with a Mafia-sponsored performer of Neomelodica from Palermo, for example, he once expressed his confusion about who was ultimately profiting from the processes of branding involving the digital circulations of his music videos, as well as the political nature of such profits. In his words:

> My [organized crime] producers pay for the promotion of my music videos on YouTube. However, if you click on the links to access these videos, YouTube will first compel you to watch a further short video advertising a FIAT car. Sometimes I wonder if Sicilian mafiosi are implicitly promoting the FIAT brand through my videos, or if FIAT is implicitly promoting my producers' brand through its digital advertisements. Or maybe are both FIAT and my producers promoting YouTube's brand through my music videos? Sometimes I get lost in these reflections and I wonder who is in charge of whom these days.

Building on this insight, current Italian dynamics of media branding seem to extend beyond organised crime forms of indirect power management, inflecting the whole Italian public sphere. During the last thirty years, for example, the coordinators of most Italian state-regulated civic organisations such as political parties and NGOs also invested impressive resources in branding activities aiming at channelling the engagement of media consumers toward visual representations of their intrinsic 'personality'. While these additional media branding activities and their political implications did not per se lead to the entrenchment of the *borghesia mafiosa* within the national public sphere, they mirrored those previously observed among organised crime leaders. In doing so, they reflected comparable consumer-oriented modalities of power management, bridging any former divide between formal and informal political approaches to the *res publica*.

Following former Italian Prime Minister and media tycoon Silvio Berlusconi's mid-1990s neoliberal reforms, and the 'mediacratic' approach to party politics he managed to implement in the country due to the quasi-monopoly he established on national televisions, ample scholarship defined the current Italians' propensity to partake in personalistic forms of media branding as a main local form of political engagement (Molè 2013; Campus 2010; Arvidsson 2006: 90). This ongoing mediatisation of politics became even more evident in the late 2000s when the growing engagement of the Italian popular classes with online social media fostered the increasing electoral success of Internet-based parties and movements. Such political formations, including the *Movimento 5 Stelle* by former TV comedian and blogger Beppe Grillo and the *Lega per Salvini Premier* by Facebook celebrity Matteo Salvini, shared a common feature: they massively engaged with digital forms of media branding concerning the public images of their leaders to gather consent (DeMatteo 2018; Caruso 2017; D'Arma 2016).

Co-founded in 2009 by Grillo and web marketing consultant Gianroberto Casaleggio, the *Movimento 5 Stelle* has been distinctive in its use of media branding techniques to elicit self-legitimating processes of consumer-based relationality among Italian social media users—and potential voters (Caruso 2017). One notable aspect of these branding techniques is the *Movimento*'s emphasis on computer-mediated interactions between its appointed leaders and supporters, as well as the informal participation of the latter in institutional decision-making via acts of online social media engagement (Caruso 2017: 594). This engagement was in turn enabled by digital campaigns of social media marketing privately sponsored by the *Movimento* via Facebook, Instagram, and YouTube, which relied on the branded public persona of Grillo himself, the political formation's official logo, and their consistent association with populistic key-terms such as 'honesty' (*onestà*) and 'courage' (*coraggio*) (Diamanti 2014).

The forms of online sociability elicited from these campaigns allowed the *Movimento* to accumulate enough political capital to win the national elections 2018.[5] Interestingly, these political campaigns of media self-branding relied on appropriations of mainstream media aesthetics comparable with those exercised by Messina Denaro and Torcasio. Many online posts sponsored by the *Movimento*, for example, portrayed Grillo dressed as a superhero. The movement's logos included aesthetic elements from 'V for Vendetta', a popular graphic novel adapted for the silver screen by Hollywood director Zack Snyder (Diamanti 2014).

The *Lega per Salvini Premier* (formerly *Lega Nord*) is a further Italian political party of populistic inspiration that has recently increased its institutional weight via campaigns of social media marketing involving the branded persona of its leader (DeMatteo 2018). Following the election of Matteo Salvini as the party's Secretary in 2013, the *Lega* sponsored a private task force of social media managers, colloquially named *La Bestia* (The Beast) (DeMatteo 2018). As revealed to me by Antonio, a *Lega*'s party cadre I interviewed in Naples, the main task of the Beast was improving the user engagement of Salvini's private social media profiles to 'stimulate symbolic relations between the intimate selves of his digital followers and the public image of the leader'.

The activities of media self-branding implemented by the Beast involved the online circulation of selfies and short videos featuring Salvini, in which he colloquially engaged with his followers during lunch breaks asking them to 'comment, like, and share' his posts to partake in his supposedly reliable and down-to-heart personality (Berti and Loner 2021). Due to the dialogic processes of interpersonal relationality between the party leader and his followers that these communication strategies elicited, Salvini's Facebook profile was able to reach five million active followers in 2023 while the *Lega* passed from 4% of electoral consent in 2013 to 34% in 2018.[6]

Salvini's daily activities of digital branding were complemented by special social media events, through which he attempted to improve the engagement of his followers with his branded persona and establish with them explicitly clientelist forms of consumer-based relationality. One of these social media contests, the so-called *Vinci Salvini* (Win Salvini), was introduced in 2019

through a short video that Salvini posted on his personal Facebook profile.[7] The video showed the *Lega*'s leader ironically acting as a television presenter, asking his followers to further increase their interactions with his social media posts for the opportunity to win a special prize. Those expressing the greatest social engagement with Salvini's social media profiles within a period would have won an in-person meeting with *Lega*'s leader himself, which would give them a chance to informally ask for his direct intervention in the resolution of their problems. Entrepreneurial tools of media brand management such as *Vinci Salvini* improved the degree of connective leadership expressed by the *Lega* on the social lives of Italian digital media users while potentially promoting offline political relations of patronage closely resembling those interconnecting Italian organised crime to its clients.

Ongoing activities of media self-branding permeate not only the promotional strategies of the *Movimento 5 Stelle* and the *Lega* but also those of other Italian political formations. Commenting on the electoral defeat suffered by the center-left Italian Democratic Party in 2019, for example, a major party cadre publicly suggested that this debacle could have been avoided by changing the name and logo of this party and associating to it new brands with strong personalistic leadership through social media engagement (Schianchi 2019). This branded approach to politics paved the way for similar trends involving further Italian state-regulated organisations, such as national and local NGOs (Costa 2022). These further civic agencies also substantially rely on media branding as primary tools to gather consent, mobilise engagement around their claims, and express connective leadership amid diverse audiences (Cammarota *et al.* 2023).

An example of this trend involved Mario, a wealthy entrepreneur from Palermo who served as director and 'founding father' of an anti-mafia NGO, and with whom I conducted several interviews. Mario established his NGO in the early 1990s during the 'Palermo Spring', a grassroots social movement that united diverse sectors of Sicilian civil society to oppose organised crime violence (Schneider and Schneider 2003). Since its foundation, the NGO has focused on organising rallies, seminars, and public initiatives that bring together local and national entrepreneurs in a broad anti-racket coalition, offering free legal support to victims of organised crime rackets. In the mid-2010s, however, the NGO experienced a strong decline in new affiliations and public participation in its initiatives. Confronted with the potential failure of his project, Mario undertook significant reforms, introducing new methods of social intervention and initiating what he referred to as 'a radical operation of rebranding'.

In 2016, Mario changed his NGO's name and logo. He replaced the NGO's original name, an acronym that plainly outlined its civic functions, with the name of a popular DJ and anti-mafia activist who had been murdered by the Mafia in the 1980s. The NGO's original logo, consisting of a series of geometric shapes, was instead replaced with a stylised portrait depicting the smiling visage of the renowned anti-mafia activist. According to Mario, this change was intended to ensure the NGO could be 'immediately associated with the personality and values embodied by this popular figure'. Following this change, the NGO scaled back the number of anti-racket initiatives it organised annually, instead re-focusing its investments on promoting its new brand through social media and launching a web radio that broadcasted news about organised crime alongside legally produced Neomelodica.

This latest initiative sought to directly challenge the activities of media branding previously instantiated by local Mafia bosses by appropriating their aesthetics, reshaping the 'personality' symbolised by Neomelodica among media consumers, and guiding the social interactions of its fans—both within and beyond Sicily—toward paths aligned with legality values. By doing so, the NGO director enhanced his civic association's ability to indirectly exert influence within the Italian public sphere, forging new networks and partnerships with local music artists and extending the reach of its activities to their respective audiences. Thanks to these media branding strategies, Mario's NGO tripled its affiliations in the following years, increasing its relevance and securing new public funding to support its initiatives.

Mafia Bourgeoisie or *Bourgeois Mafia*? Connective Leadership and the Italian Neoliberal Upper Classes

The previous case studies exemplified how current upper-class Italians involved in either criminal or state-regulated organisations tend to use media self-branding similarly to mobilise comparable forms of connective leadership among their audiences. As I will show in this section by comparing such case studies, the relational processes engendered by media self-branding indeed enable their upper-class protagonists to engage in self-legitimising accumulation of social and symbolic capital, increasing their political agency vi-à-vis their audiences. Of course, not all the branding activities in question engendered new instantiation of the *borghesia mafiosa.* Nevertheless, they all cooperated indirectly to foster forms of civic participation and upper-class privilege reproduction transcending the conceptual boundaries between formal and informal, as they were neither regulated nor mediated by state power.

As seen before, the media self-branding processes in which organised crime bosses such as Messina Denaro, Torcasio, and those sponsoring Neomelodica engaged did not only enable them to expand the clientelist webs to new forms of mafia bourgeoisie. These media processes also helped their organisations to be perceived as authoritative and effective political institutions by their audiences, despite state bureaucracy defining them as blatantly illegal. Structurally similar media self-branding activities allowed the leaders of political parties like the *Movimento 5 Stelle* and Salvini's *Lega* to enhance their popularity and obtain sounding electoral victories, despite their polarising and overall populistic political offers. Media self-branding also enabled Mario the NGO director to successfully promote his anti-mafia agenda among new audiences, enhance his NGO's prestige, and unlock new public funding, despite having reduced the services that his NGO provided to its members.

Perhaps more importantly, all the activities of media self-branding described thus far, and their socio-political effects, seem informed by eminently capitalist internal dynamics. Their capacity to 'be political' hinged on highly commodified symbolic representations of the (more or less imagined) respective 'personalities' of their branders, in tandem with their commercial marketing across rings of media consumers (Arvidson 2006; Lury 2004). Moreover, these self-branding activities have been sponsored by risk-taking entrepreneurial subjects who mobilised diversely empowered clientships toward individualistic market choices as an effective way for them to engage in political actions (Chatterjee 2004; Comaroff and Comaroff 2001).

As such, the self-branders' capacity to legitimize and enhance their social and symbolic capital depended on their ability to extract value from the relational labour of media consumers, who could, in turn, act themselves politically as small-scale media entrepreneurs by re-circulating the brands in question (e.g.: via social media) to their own (real or perceived) advantage (Baym 2015; Elyachar 2010). For instance, relational labour was evident in the efforts of Neomelodica performers, who adopted Camorra-sponsored aesthetics to pursue social mobility vis-à-vis their fans; but also in the actions of 'Vinci Salvini' participants, who dreamed of receiving important personal favours from their favourite party leader. Similarly, Luisa embarked on forms of relational labour by repeatedly sharing and commenting on Torcasio's Facebook posts within a tight community of digital followers.

Accordingly, the dynamics of connective leadership exhibited by the Italian upper-class branders discussed so far seem to be shaped by capitalist cultural narratives and 'free market' discourses of consumer-based participation in the public sphere that, as reminded earlier, also deeply influence the inner functioning of contemporary neoliberal democracies (Harvey 2005). One of these discourses, for example, praises the advantages of exercising political agency via unregulated market practices, rather than state bureaucracy (Comaroff and Comaroff 2001). The circulation of organised-crime-sponsored neomelodic aesthetics and social media content, for example, is not *per se* sanctioned by Italian laws (at least when, as it usually happens, the outlets involved in it are indirectly sponsored, rather than owned, by criminals). Similarly, no specific law regulates the

consumerist engagement of Italian audiences with branded political messages like those provided by Mario's digital radio or Torcasio's Facebook group, nor the personalistic advantages unlocked by the 'Vinci Salvini' social media challenge.

Further neoliberal discourses informed the upper-class branders' perceived necessity to entertain a constant state of warlike competition against each other concerning the marketing of their brands among common audiences, thereby avoiding intra-class concertations and promoting their political agencies in rather individualising terms (Hardt and Negri 2004: 187). This is evident in the case of political parties competing for the same voter base through privately sponsored social media campaigns, which rely on commodified portrayals of their self-branded leaders, emphasising their ability to bring positive change as exceptional individuals rather than as representatives of pluralistic civic organisations. But it is also the case for the Sicilian Mafia bosses appropriating the Neomelodica brand from the Camorra via their investments in the local media, as well as Mario the NGO director further appropriating the same Neomelodica brand for himself to subvert its inner 'personality' and elicit counter-hegemonic dynamics of sociability out of its consumption.

Another eminently neoliberal discourse characterising the activities of media self-branding in question concerns the self-branders' perceived necessity to legitimize their social positionalities, and overall upper-class class privilege, via market-based dynamics of consent accumulation, rather than collective concertations or state-regulated socio-legal frameworks. Based on this discourse, the connective leadership elicited by the self-branders is not aimed at exercising direct political control over their audiences (Poell *et al.* 2016: 1004). Its goal is instead 'activating social networks and managing the constant stream of user activity' toward convenient directions by establishing informal and seemingly spontaneous interpersonal relationships with diverse media consumers (Poell *et al.* 2016: 1005).

The unregulated features of this peculiar form of political leadership, and the dynamics of class-privilege reproduction it elicits in context, are further highlighted by the fact that the upper-class people involved in the activities of self-branding thus far described did not necessarily need to enjoy socio-legally determined ownership over the means of production through which their brands were designed and circulated to extract social and symbolic values from their audiences' habits of media consumption. Despite their entrepreneurial features, these self-branders reproduced their upper-class privilege in a way that differs significantly from the capitalist upper classes described in classical Marxian theory. Within the Marxian framework, the uneven social hierarchies characterising capitalist societies are shaped by the upper classes' ownership of the means of production, in tandem with their capacity to reproduce their dominant role in society (including their capacity to influence state power itself) via the exploitative processes of value accumulation that such conditions of ownership socio-legally legitimate them to exercise versus non-bourgeois labour forces (Marx 2019 [1867]).

This was not the case for those Italian legal or illegal upper-class branders investing in the circulation of specific imaginaries across social media platforms and software formally owned by multinational corporations such as Facebook, WhatsApp, and YouTube. Nor it was the case for those moulding their brands (and their respective 'personalities') via imaginaries that have already been designed, marketed, and socio-legally owned in terms of copyright laws by transnational media producers (e.g.: Messina Denaro, Torcasio, and the *Movimento 5 Stelle* appropriating Hollywood aesthetics) or localised media content creators (e.g.: the Sicilian Mafia appropriating Neomelodica from the Camorra; Salvini performing as an Italian national TV entertainer; Mario electing the portrait of an activist/DJ as his NGO's brand).

The further branding activities carried out by these additional media entities, which intersect those managed simultaneously by organised crime and state-regulated civic organisations, suggest that the forms of connective leadership and class privilege reproduction elicited by media branding in today's Italy, in tandem with their unregulated features, are not limited to the specific actors discussed in this paper. Instead, they seem to be a defining feature of the

neoliberal Italian public sphere as a whole, underscoring a harsh crisis of the state-regulated socio-legal frameworks that, at least in theory, should discipline its functioning.

Building on these considerations, the upper-class politics elicited by the circulation of brands in contemporary Italy implicitly legitimize and reproduce the older and newer instantiations of the *borghesia mafiosa* recently evoked by Chief Prosecutor De Lucia. Indeed, these social formations have historically operated at the intersection of the legal and the extra-legal, relying on privately established relational connections between criminal organisations and state-regulated institutions to secure personalistic forms of socio-economic advantage and the reproduction of class privilege. Due to the pivotal role played by media self-branding within current Italian neoliberal dynamics of power management, upper-class forms of connective leadership ultimately reproduce the relevance of the so-called *borghesia mafiosa* within the country's cultural imaginary, *de facto* contributing to increasing its ranks. In this sense, one might also wonder if the notion of *mafia bourgeoisie* employed by De Lucia to describe the social forces preventing Messina Denaro from being arrested for so long, and overall reproducing organised crime violence in today's Italy, should not be extended to all those contemporary elements of *bourgeois mafia* who, by strategically investing in self-branded imaginaries, have contributed to blur most fundamental differences between licit and illicit political mobilisation in the country.

Conclusions

The increasing inclination of major Italian criminal organisations toward political activities of media self-branding does not appear inherently subversive of the neoliberal dynamics of power management characterising the public sphere of contemporary Italy. On the contrary, this tendency fits coherently into a broader socio-cultural context of political action, where legal and extra-legal agencies indirectly cooperate via comparable modalities of consumer-based relationality, facilitated by their parallel entrepreneurial involvement in cultural productions and media marketing. In this context, the individual consumption of private imaginaries, rather than the collective deliberation of public affairs, seems a foundational factor inspiring upper-class modalities of class privilege reproduction and overall approach to the public sphere, including those involving the *borghesia mafiosa*.

In essence, personalistic self-branding and the mechanics of media circulation through which it happens have become central tools of upper-class class privilege reproduction not only for the members of Italian criminal organisations but also for the coordinators and operators of political parties, NGOs, and many other traditionally bureaucratised 'bourgeois' platforms of civic engagement, as they seek to shape public perception of their respective agencies through their relational entanglement with media consumers. Far from being structured by fixed socio-legal frameworks or the customary models of normativity that criminal leaders might violently impose over their clientships (e.g.: rules for assessing territorial control, codes of honour, etc.), media self-branding enables the contemporary Italian upper classes to exert indirect influence over the consumer habits and relational lives of their audiences by fostering interpersonal conditions of connective leadership. These conditions closely mirror the relational dynamics that interconnect Italian organised crime with historical and current manifestations of the mafia bourgeoisie, as they are both characterised by market-inspired systems of asymmetric reciprocity and ongoing exchange of favours.

By relying on immaterial forms of relational labour, nevertheless, the processes of media self-branding considered by this paper are by their interpersonal nature signified by ongoing dynamics of cultural negotiation among all the parties involved. Being culturally productive, therefore, upper-class processes of media self-branding might ultimately contribute to further reshaping the neoliberal discourses that originally legitimised them in the first place, as well as their protagonists' social positionalities and class identities. Therefore, I would like to conclude this paper by emphasising the need for a broader interdisciplinary debate on the role played by media self-branding not only in current dynamics of upper-class class privilege reproduction but also in potential processes of cultural production engendering future processes of social change within the Italian neoliberal public sphere.

This debate would need to consider the crisis currently faced by industrial economies and state bureaucracies as primary disciplining tools shaping the public sphere of neoliberal democracies and their increasing replacement with social practices of value production such as those made available by media branding. By the same token, it should also consider how the forms of power management on which most capitalist systems of privilege reproduction, and overall cultural hegemony, have historically hinged have been effectively replaced with consumer-based approaches to the public sphere tending to bypass former discursive divides between legal and extra-legal politics and economies. The insights evolving from this debate shall ultimately elucidate the complementary contributions of licit and illicit instantiations of the current upper classes (including transnational forms of *borghesia mafiosa*) to transnational milieus of neoliberal governance that, as the current Italian one, are increasingly disciplined by capitalist practices of social mediation and clientelist relationality.

Notes

1. As expressed by a growing body of literature in political anthropology, the increasing prominence of personalistic activities of media self-branding within the political life of neoliberal democracies, in tandem with the affective dynamics they engender among variously empowered classes of citizens-consumers, is one of the main factors fomenting the rise of rather divisive forms institutional populism and authoritarian governance in such contexts (Mazzarella 2020; Gustersonn 2017). While assessing these insights goes beyond the scope of this paper, it can be hypothesised that the authoritarian forms of power management exercised by criminal bosses like Messina Denaro, as well as their cultural legitimation by the Italian *borghesia mafiosa*, could have been further fostered by the populist imaginaries that the boss circulated through self-branding activities aimed at his audiences.
2. See, e.g., Allum 2006; Lupo 2011; DIA 2022.
3. Building on the classic working definition by Thrasher (2013 [1927]) and its more recent re-elaborations by Hagedorn (2008) and Venkatesh (1997), I define here the term 'gang' as a loosely structured, territorially based, and socially embedded extra-legal organisation providing their members with common 'interstitial' identities and sets of socio-economic services in opposition to those offered them by public institutions. Most literature avoids addressing Italian criminal organisations as 'gangs', due to their sophisticated organisational features, preferring to use this term to address criminal groups typical of the Americas. However, current scholarship presents slightly differing views on the internal structures exhibited by Mafia, Camorra, and 'Ndrangheta in their early stages. For instance, Lupo (2011) and Marmo (2012) highlight continuities between the organisational features of these groups in the 19th century and their present-day operations. Allum (2006), Gambetta (1996), and Barbagallo (2011) contend that early manifestations of Italian organised crime operated with looser hierarchies than their modern counterparts. Despite these differences, both perspectives concur that 19th-century southern Italian criminal groups align with the definition of 'gang' I provided before. In both form and function, these early instantiations of the Italian underworld bore a closer resemblance to current street gangs in Latin America and the US than highly structured transnational cartels.
4. A so-called Camorra clan is one of the many administrative units composing the Camorra.
5. See: https://elezionistorico.interno.gov.it/ Last accessed: 17/04/2024.
6. See: https://elezionistorico.interno.gov.it/ Last accessed: 13/12/2024.
7. See: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=AtWldbxcFPc&t=20 Last accessed: 13/12/2024.

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